

Footprint wizard and footprint editor.

The software comes with a wizard kind of tool that helps you in creating footprints easily, so that you do not have to labour through the process like in some other tools.

Apart from the footprints available in the Footprint Library, you can create footprints for a variety of standard packages using this wizard and edit those existing ones using Footprint Editor. You can also add and edit the pins in the footprints, eliminating any limitations that are usually seen with competing products.

Import netlist from any schematic editor. If you already have a favourite schematic editor, you do not have to leave it while moving over to FreePCB. While you can surely generate a netlist within FreePCB, you also have the flexibility to import it from any other schematic editing program that can output a PADS format netlist. Moreover, once you do this, you can then manually place the components and route traces between the pins of the components to continue work.

Design rule checking. Practically there are certain lower limits on trace widths, pad sizes and clearances between copper features and/or holes, called Design Rules which vary depending upon the manufac-

turing process that you plan to use, should your design be approved for production. FreePCB has a Design Rule Checker which checks your PCB design for compliance with a set of design rules provided by the PCB manufacturer.

Easily share output. The person to whom you send your file does not need to have a copy of FreePCB to be able to view it, as there are multiple ways in which the file can be shared with others for viewing. The tool outputs RS-274X-formatted Gerber file data and a drill file, which you can use to make boards of sizes up to 152cm by 152cm. There are also many options available for Gerber file outputs and dimensions, as per your requirement, which can be viewed in any free Gerber Viewer.

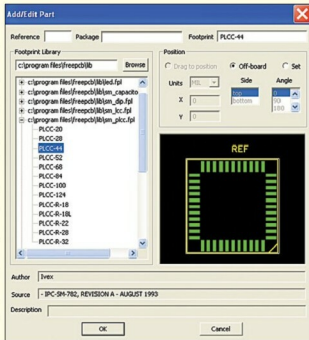


Fig. 2: Add/edit part

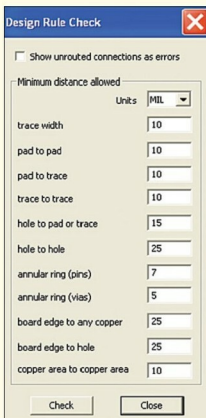


Fig. 3: Design rule check

Decent GUI. The main elements of the GUI window are the menu bar, the taskbar immediately below the menu bar and the layer list on the left side of the client area, showing its colour and visibility, the selection mask below the layer list, with options to enable/disable selection of various items, the layout window showing the PCB, the function key menu below the layer list and layout window which shows the available function key commands and the status bar at the bottom.

Setting units and grids. The taskbar contains eight shortcuts for various file and edit options along with five

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